

From Reformation to Recession:  
The Contradictory Legacy of the Mexican Revolution

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The Mexican Revolution, which lasted from 1910 to 1917, emerged from decades of social inequality, political repression, and economic concentration under Porfirio Diaz's regime, inspiring millions of peasants, workers, and intellectuals to mobilize for a more just and democratic nation. As time progressed, revolutionary leaders sought to rebuild Mexico on new foundations by expanding education, protecting labor rights, redistributing lands, and redefining national sovereignty. However, the Revolution's legacy becomes a challenge, since its achievements were followed by profound contradictions between a democratic aspiration as the main structure of the government and the political order that takes advantage of the political system. Although the Mexican Revolution achieved significant social progress, especially through the creation of a secular education system and the establishment of the constitutional protection of labor and land rights, it ultimately failed to establish a genuine democratic order. The Revolution's promises eroded away due to the rise of a centralized single-party state and the continued marginalization of vulnerable communities, revealing a political system that serves the elite's interests above the people who called for liberation.

Firstly, the impact of the Mexican Revolution would establish a modernized education system that sought to benefit the Mexican population by expanding opportunities for learning and national development. One of the clearest examples of this transformation appeared in the work of José Vasconcelos, who served as Mexico's Secretary of Education, where he approached the position with "boundless energy and idealism."<sup>1</sup> Notably, Vasconcelos expanded the education system within the rural and Indigenous communities, promoting literacy, which

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<sup>1</sup> Vasconcelos, Jose. "The Cosmic Race" in *The Mexico Reader: History, Culture, Politics*, edited by Gilbert M. Joseph and Timothy J. Henderson. Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 2022. 17.

oversaw the production of inexpensive workbooks and textbooks, while also supporting artistic development through the Ministry of Public Education and Department of Fine Arts. Of course, Vasconcelos' reforms represented a decisive break from the Porfirian era, when the education system was limited and often inaccessible to the rural community. The ideological foundations of Vasconcelos' reforms can be traced back to the Revolution's journalists, such as Ricardo Flores Magon, who argued that Mexico must be guided by the "light of Science" and liberated from the corruption that had stained the Porfiriato.<sup>2</sup> Magon believed that education and scientific reasoning were essential for empowering citizens and creating a just society, which the Porfirian regime was not able to provide. Together, Vasconcelos' education initiatives and Magon's revolutionary critique reveal that one of the Revolution's most meaningful successes was its commitment to expanding knowledge and promoting intellectual development, which laid the groundwork for a more informed and enlightened citizenry throughout the republic, whether in urban or rural areas.

Secondly, the Mexican Revolution helped redefine the political legitimacy within the nation by restoring the constitutional principles of the Republic and challenging leaders who betrayed the people's demand for justice. Indeed, Revolutionary leaders did not simply seek to replace one regime with another, but they aimed to reestablish the authority of a government that's rooted in law, sovereignty, and the will of the people. Significantly, Benito Juárez's earlier republican example became a powerful ideological reference for the Constitutionalist faction within the revolution, as his 1867 proclamation emphasized that Mexicans had fought to prevent

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<sup>2</sup> Magon, Ricardo Flores, "Land and Liberty" in *The Mexico Reader: History, Culture, Politics*, edited by Gilbert M. Joseph and Timothy J. Henderson. Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 2022. 280.

losing their freedom and their sovereignty, reaffirming that national stability depended on constitutional governance rather than personal rule.<sup>3</sup> In other words, Venustiano Carranza and his supporters adopted this framework to legitimize their struggle against usurpers and to restore the institutional integrity of the Mexican state. At the same time, Emiliano Zapata's Plan of Ayala demonstrated a complementary demand for political legitimacy. Zapata condemned Francisco I. Madero for betraying the revolution's promises and asserted that only a government truly representing the people could claim rightful authority.<sup>4</sup> In other words, his call for the removal of corrupt leadership echoed the broader revolutionary insistence that power must serve the nation, not the ambitions of dictatorial rulers. Together, both Juárez and Zapata reveal how the Revolution reshaped the meaning of legitimate governance by challenging corruption, invoking republican ideals, and asserting that authority must be grounded in justice and constitutional principles.

Thirdly, with the help of the Constitutionalist, the Mexican Revolution achieved one of its most significant successes in establishing the 1917 Constitution of the United Mexican States, which enforces several articles that would protect the human dignity of all Mexicans within the workforce, while nationalizing its own land, water, and resources from foreign extraction. Of course, the Constitutionalist, led by Venustiano Carranza after defeating Francisco Villa,

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<sup>3</sup> Juárez, Benito. "The Triumph of the Republic" in *The Mexico Reader: History, Culture, Politics*, edited by Gilbert M. Joseph and Timothy J. Henderson. Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 2022. 233 - 235.

<sup>4</sup> Zapata, Emiliano. "Plan of Ayala" in *The Mexico Reader: History, Culture, Politics*, edited by Gilbert M. Joseph and Timothy J. Henderson. Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 2022. 283 – 285.

convened the Constitutional Convention in Queretaro and produced the 1917 Constitution, which is a document that represented a decisive break from the Porfirian economic model and the widespread exploitation that had fueled revolutionary anger. When analyzing both Article 27 and 123, it reflects the revolutionaries' commitment to social justice and national sovereignty. Importantly, Article 27 prohibits the unchecked extraction of Mexico's natural resources by foreign companies and establishes the nation's ownership of its land and subsoil, marking a fundamental assertion of economic independence.<sup>5</sup> Moreover, Article 123 addressed the longstanding abuses faced by workers by guaranteeing labor rights such as fair wages, the eight-hour workday, protections for women and children, and the right to strike.<sup>6</sup> These reforms demonstrated the Revolution's attempt to institutionalize its ideals by embedding protections for workers and national patrimony directly into constitutional law. While political leaders continued to struggle over how these provisions would be enforced in practice, the Constitution itself symbolized a major victory for the revolutionary demand to restore dignity and justice to ordinary Mexicans. While this gives the sensation that the Revolution succeeded in transforming the legal foundation of the nation, in practice, everything goes in a different direction when it comes to the post-Revolutionary era.

However, the Revolution's effort to consolidate national authority ultimately laid the foundation for the emergence of a centralized single-party state that contradicted the democratic aspirations of many revolutionaries. For instance, Plutarco Elias Calles, who rose to prominence

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<sup>5</sup> "The Constitution of 1917: Articles 27 and 123" in *The Mexico Reader: History, Culture, Politics*, edited by Gilbert M. Joseph and Timothy J. Henderson, Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 2022. 348 – 350.

<sup>6</sup> "The Constitution of 1917," 351.

during the post-revolutionary period, articulated a political vision that emphasized the need for Mexico to become a “nation of institutions and laws,” where he rejects authoritarian leadership in favor of a durable state structure.<sup>7</sup> Ironically, this call for institutionalizing Mexico did not result in pluralism; instead, Calles founded the *Partido Nacional Revolucionario* (PNR), a political organization designed to unify revolutionary elites under a single mechanism of power. While Calles framed this project as a safeguard of democracy against authoritarianism and instability, it concentrated political authority within the single party by their own elites. As a matter of fact, Carlos Fuentes highlights the consequences of this design, arguing that the post-revolutionary state was shaped by individuals who, despite their revolutionary ideals of democracy and stability, abandoned their cause to gain power and stability within the system. According to Fuentes, the emerging single-party system was later governed through corruption, where the bureaucrats were self-interested, while practicing an appearance of democracy, but only among the same political leaders.<sup>8</sup> This dramatic transformation revealed a profound contradiction: the Revolution that was promised for political liberation gave rise to a system capable of repressing dissent and marginalizing alternative voices. In this way, the creation of the

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<sup>7</sup> Calles, Plutarco Elias, “Mexico Must Become a Nation of Institutions and Laws” in *The Mexico Reader: History, Culture, Politics*, edited by Gilbert M. Joseph and Timothy J. Henderson, 349–351. Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 2022. 370 – 372.

<sup>8</sup> Fuentes, Carlos, “The Formation of the Single-Party State” in *The Mexico Reader: History, Culture, Politics*, edited by Gilbert M. Joseph and Timothy J. Henderson, 349–351. Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 2022. 375 - 376.

PNR, later evolved as *Partido Revolucionario Institucional* (PRI), represented not the fulfillment of revolutionary democracy, but the consolidation of a political order that controlled the government and its citizens through the “Perfect Dictatorship.”

While the 1917 Constitution was established for the purpose of enforcing laws that offered rights and social protections for all Mexican citizens, many of its ideals were not fully enforced, which formed a tension between revolutionary rhetoric and political reality. Calles emphasizes that the Revolution’s achievements remain fragile and vulnerable to both internal division and conservative resurgence, where he argues that if the revolutionary coalition were to be fractured by an individual’s “ambition, intrigue, or arrogance,” then the conservatives would take advantage to overthrow the revolution’s social gains.<sup>9</sup> While Calles presents himself as the guardian of the Revolution, his insistence on unity also reveals how post-revolutionary leaders feared losing control and often prioritized political unity over constitutional enforcement. As a result, many revolutionists who fought for a greater cause later describe that the Revolution was like a “hurricane” that stripped individuals’ autonomy and left them as “a lowly leaf blown wildly about by the winds.”<sup>10</sup> Indeed, this metaphor captures the disillusionment felt by many Mexicans who, despite the Constitution’s progressive reforms, lived under leaders who claimed themselves as protectors of the Revolution, but failed to deliver on its democratic aspirations. In other words, it illustrates how the Revolution’s constitutional ideals were overshadowed by

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<sup>9</sup> Calles, “Mexico Must Become a Nation of Institutions and Laws,” 373.

<sup>10</sup> Azuela, Mariano. *The Underdogs: A Novel of the Mexican Revolution*. Foreword by Carlos Fuentes. New York: Penguin Groups, 2008. 60.

political struggles that often betrayed its original promise to improve and bring social justice to all Mexican citizens.

As a result, the Mexican's distrust of the post-revolutionary state deepened even more as the PRI elites failed to fulfill their promises in improving social and economic conditions. In context, the Revolution mobilized peasants with the promise of land redistribution and rural justice that they had lost during and before the Porfirian regime, but the reality of implementation often fell far short of expectations. To demonstrate, there have been occasions where there's a sense of betrayal from the peasants when they receive the lands from the government's elites, yet they discover that it is utterly useless terrain, while the government officials congratulate themselves for fulfilling the "promises" of the revolution.<sup>11</sup> Indeed, the men within the story walk around the desolate terrain in silence, where they were disappointed in the broader failure of the state for not enforcing the agrarian reform as it should be. After all, the men didn't receive from the government fertile property that could sustain agriculture, but the opposite, a land that does not produce anything, which comes back with the same inequalities that the Revolution fought against. This illustrates that the Mexican citizens were dissatisfied and skeptical of the government, which supposedly represented the people, but was not fulfilling their promises. In a similar way, the PRI, which took control over all the government and institutions, failed to enforce the agrarian reform, becoming a political system that contradicted the very purpose of the Mexican Revolution.

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<sup>11</sup> Rulfo, Juan. "They Gave Us the Land" in *The Mexico Reader: History, Culture, Politics*, edited by Gilbert M. Joseph and Timothy J. Henderson, 349–351. Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 2022. 407 – 408.



In addition, the Revolution failed to transform the structural inequalities that shaped life in rural Mexico, where Indigenous and Afro-Mexican communities remained trapped in social hierarchies that had existed since the colonial era. To elaborate, there was a study of La Costa Chica, which it revealed that Afro-Mexican communities continued to face entrenched racial and economic marginalization, even if it was after the Mexican Revolution. For instance, the Afro-Mexican communities in La Costa Chica remained excluded from meaningful political participation and economic opportunities, while the local power structure still offers privilege among light-skinned elites, known as *blanquitos*.<sup>12</sup> What this indicates is that there's still a continuity among the Afro-Mexican communities in La Costa Chica, where the post-revolutionary government could not deliver substantive improvements among the rural population throughout the republic. In the same way, there's an argument from an anthropologist, Guillermo Bonfil Batalla, who argued that the Mexican state constructed an "imaginary Mexico" that is grounded in Western ideals of modernity, homogeneity, and progress, which marginalize the Indigenous culture and erase the plural realities of the nation.<sup>13</sup> What Batalla argues is that the post-revolutionary government imposed a cultural project that denied the legitimacy of *Mexico Profundo*, which is the living Mesoamerican civilization that's practiced by the majority of the population, that is, both Indigenous and rural communities. In doing so, the state sought to

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<sup>12</sup> Beltran, Gonzalo Aguirre, "La Costa Chica and the Struggles of Mexico's 'Third Root'" in *The Mexico Reader: History, Culture, Politics*, edited by Gilbert M. Joseph and Timothy J. Henderson. Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 2022. 491 – 493.

<sup>13</sup> Batalla, Guillermo Bonfil. "The Problem of National Culture" in *The Mexico Reader: History, Culture, Politics*, edited by Gilbert M. Joseph and Timothy J. Henderson. Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 2022. 30 – 33.

replace the Mesoamerican civilization with an elite vision rooted in European norms, instead of integrating their cultural heritage within the nation's identity. Therefore, both cases reveal how the post-Revolutionary government celebrated its nationalist image of progress and modernity, while enforcing the elite minority's culture to practice Western civilization and neglecting the popular culture of the majority.

While political corruption was made known by workers, professors, and students' protests, the Mexican government's response to public criticism during the 1960s demonstrated the extent to which the Revolution's democratic promises had deteriorated. To put it in context, the student movement of 1968 exposed how far the state was willing to go to preserve its authority, despite using its laws and institutions under the PRI to justify its authority over the country. Because of this, President Gustavo Diaz Ordaz deployed military forces to crush the protest, which caused the horrific event, known as the Massacre of Tlatelolco, from the state against its own people. According to one testimony during the massacre, there were scenes of chaos and brutality as soldiers opened fire on both unarmed students and bystanders, including families, while the military, by order of President Ordaz, would threaten and insult the journalists, photographers, and editors.<sup>14</sup> This event marked all Mexican citizens in distrusting their government, where supposedly the state argues that they continue the legacy of the Revolutionary ideals, yet the PRI becomes an authoritarian regime that suppresses anyone who attempts to criticize the government. Thus, the government's violent response to peaceful protest

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<sup>14</sup> Poniatowska, Elena, "The Student Movement of 1968," in *The Mexico Reader: History, Culture, Politics*, edited by Gilbert M. Joseph and Timothy J. Henderson, 349–351. Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 2022. 508 – 510.

reflects a profound failure of the Revolution's democratic project and a betrayal of the principles it once claimed to uphold.

Lastly, the PRI's ability to dominate national politics for more than seventy years exposes one of the Revolution's most serious failures, that is, the ability to construct a democratic system where other candidates from different parties can compete with one another. While the Revolution promised all Mexican citizens to have a government that reflected their will, the PRI perfected a political system that allowed them to manipulate the electoral system and ensured their power over the republic. Evidently, former president Vicente Fox, the first opposition candidate to defeat the PRI in 2000, argues that the party's politicians routinely manipulated the electoral process so that voters would still vote for the same party for over seventy years, creating an illusion of democracy, while ensuring their outcome that benefits the party.<sup>15</sup> Of course, this case reveals the corruption of the government for not establishing a pluralist system of different political parties to compete with one another, but also causes distrust in the governmental institutions. To demonstrate, Mariano Azuela's revolutionary character would argue in regards the contradiction between revolutionary ideals and political reality in the following quote: "We did not rise up in arms so that some Carranza or some Villa could become president of the republic. We fight on behalf of the sacred rights of the people, stomped upon by

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<sup>15</sup> Weisbrot, Mark and Vicente Fox, "Assessing NAFTA: Before and After" in *The Mexico Reader: History, Culture, Politics*, edited by Gilbert M. Joseph and Timothy J. Henderson. Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 2022. 684 – 686.

the evil cacique.”<sup>16</sup> This statement encapsulates the frustration of those who fought in the Mexican Revolution, where they attempted to establish a democratic government that represented the people and improved their lifestyle. But this quote becomes a frustration that echoes the sentiments of many Mexicans who felt that the Revolution’s sacrifices have been in vain since the new political elite governs the nation under their authoritarian regime, giving them more representation than the people who sought justice. Hence, the PRI’s disruption of the democratic process represents a deep betrayal of the Revolution’s true ideal for justice, representation, and political accountability.

In the end, while the Mexican Revolution expanded education and secured new constitutional protections for workers and landholders, it fell short of creating a democratic nation that it envisioned, all while the single-party rule and the persistent social inequalities continued to place power in the hands of the elites rather than the people. The successes of Vasconcelos’ educational reforms and the transformative guarantees embedded in Articles 27 and 123 reveal the Revolution’s attempt to improve social welfare and national sovereignty throughout the republic. However, these advances were undermined by the long-term consolidation of political authority under the PRI, which abused the revolutionary ideals and used them as an instrument to centralize its power over the nation. From the marginalization against the Indigenous, African-Mexican, and rural communities all the way to the abuse of power to suppress their citizens exposed the contradiction of the post-revolutionary state as the source of the Revolution’s cause. By examining both accomplishments and its failures, it

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<sup>16</sup> Azuela, Mariano. *The Underdogs: A Novel of the Mexican Revolution*. Foreword by Carlos Fuentes. New York: Penguin Groups, 2008. 92.

becomes clearer that the Revolution not only redefined Mexico's national identity, but also struggled to align the post-revolutionary authoritarian regime with the people's aspiration for a true democratic political system, not a "perfect dictatorship" that abuses them.

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